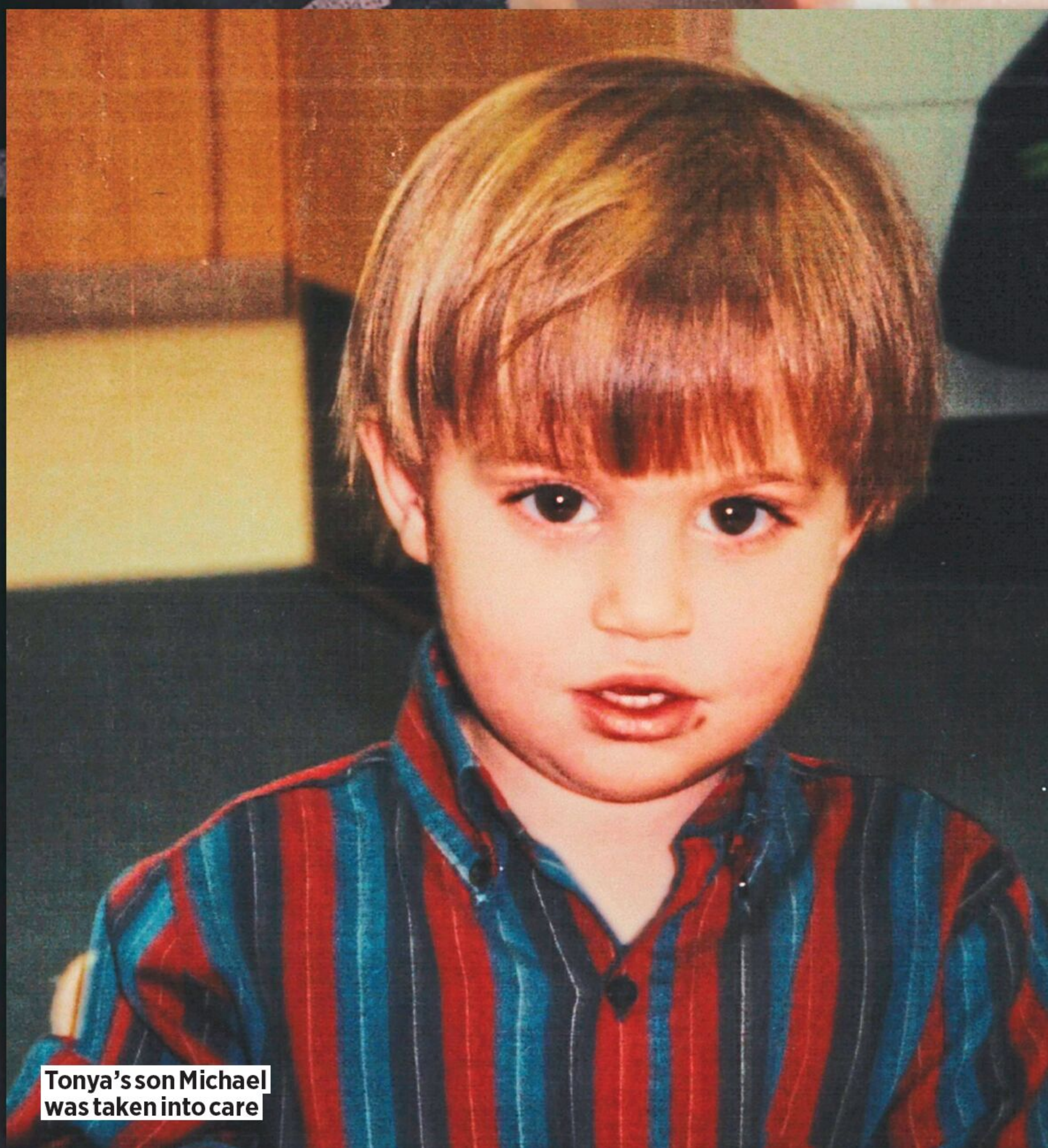
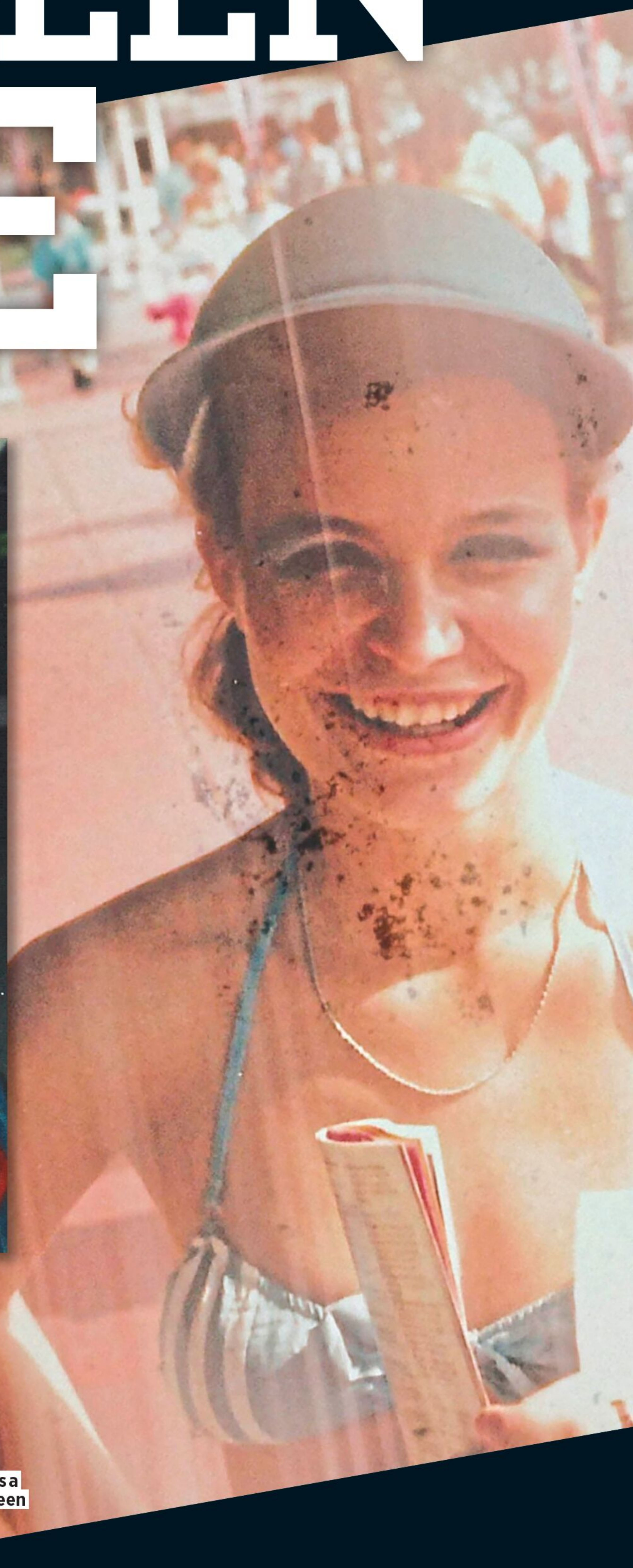


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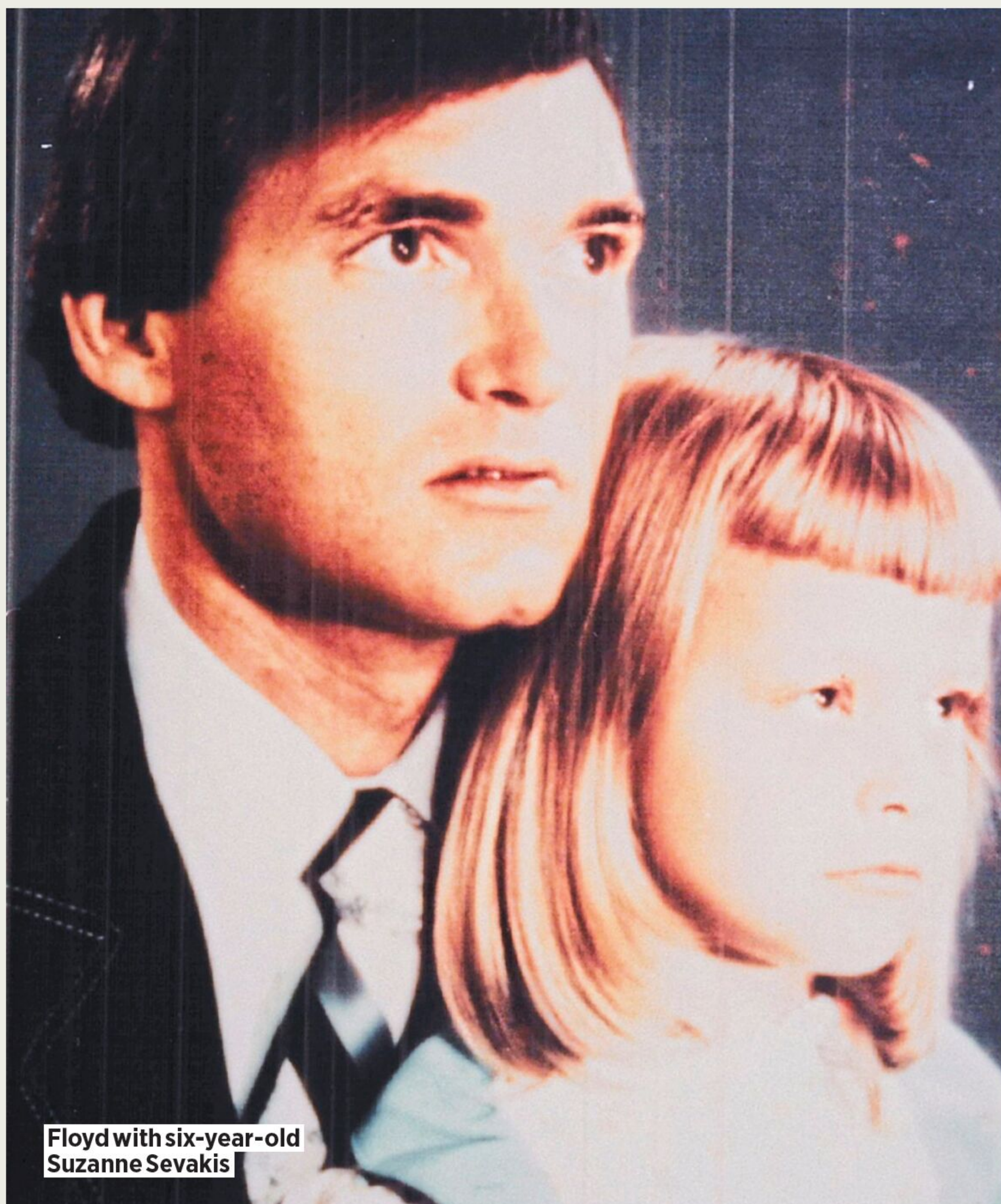
A STOLEN LIFE



Tonya's son Michael was taken into care

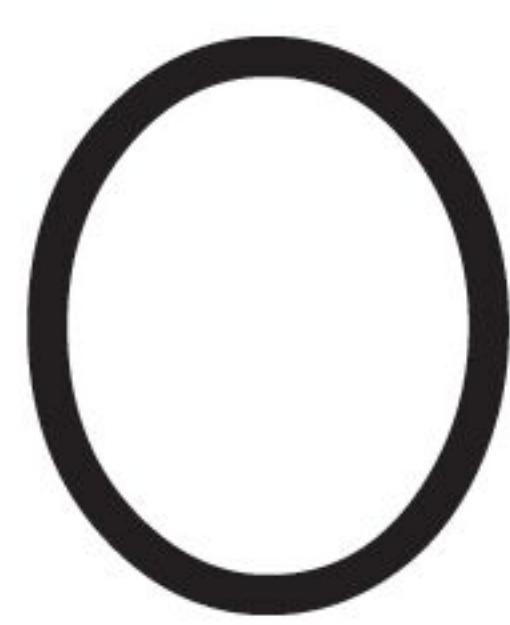


Sharon Marshall was a bright and bubbly teen



Floyd with six-year-old Suzanne Sevakis

WHEN A WOMAN WAS FOUND DYING, IT UNRAVELLED A CASE OF ABDUCTION AND ABUSE GOING BACK DECADES



On a gloomy night in April 1990, three men were driving along in Oklahoma City when they came across what looked like the scene of a hit and run. Pulling

over to investigate, they found a young woman unconscious by the side of the road. The woman – later identified as 20-year-old Tonya Hughes, an exotic dancer from Tulsa – was rushed to hospital, where she remained in intensive care with severe head trauma for five days, before succumbing to her injuries.

It seemed like an accident, made all the more tragic by the fact she left behind a two-year-old son, Michael. But there was something off about Tonya's husband Clarence. He was much older than his wife and, when he arrived at the hospital, he didn't want

anyone to see her. Tonya's doctors also found evidence of historic injuries, suggesting there may have been abuse in the household. But they couldn't have imagined what was really going on.

When Tonya died, her friends called her mother to offer their condolences, only to be told her daughter had died two decades ago, when she was 18 months old. Whoever the dead woman was, she wasn't Tonya Hughes – so who was she? What followed was a tale so unbelievable, documentary *Girl In The Picture* hit Netflix's number one slot when it was released. Here's why...

SHARON

The story starts with a teenager called Sharon Marshall. Beautiful, bubbly and popular, she was an exceptional student. She was in the gifted programme at Forest Park High School in Georgia, and aspired to work

as an aerospace engineer. It was a dream that was well within her grasp, too, as she was offered a full scholarship to study at the Georgia Institute of Technology. The only dark spot was her home life. Sharon's mother had died, and it had fallen to her to do all the domestic duties for her domineering father, Warren. And, as she got older, it became horrifyingly apparent Warren was sexually abusing his daughter.

In the documentary, Sharon's high-school friend Jenny Fisher describes how she had been at the Marshalls' trailer one evening when she found some risqué lingerie in her teenage friend's room. When quizzed about it, Sharon confessed her father had bought it for her. Then, Warren arrived home, bursting into the room brandishing a gun. After forcing Jenny to lie on the floor with a pillow over her face, he raped his daughter at gunpoint. Shockingly, the next day, Sharon asked Jenny not to say anything, telling her, "Daddy's just like that – let it go."

Getting away to college could have saved Sharon, but at 18, she got pregnant. At that point, she decided to run away, heading to Alabama with her boyfriend. However, he woke up one day to find Sharon gone, a note telling him she had left with her father. She then disappeared, and none of her friends heard from her again, or ever found out what had happened to the baby she was expecting.

TONYA

In 1989, Tonya Hughes arrived in Tulsa, Oklahoma, with her husband Clarence and started working at a local strip club. She soon made friends, but no one liked Clarence, who seemed domineering. Tonya often appeared with bruises, and at one point, she confided to a friend she was afraid of her husband, who had



Sharon Marshall

'THEY RAN DNA AND THERE WAS NO MATCH - HE WASN'T THE DAD'

taken out a life insurance policy on her. The couple's son Michael was the apple of Tonya's eye, but Clarence seemed possessive of the little boy. When a fellow dancer told Tonya to leave Clarence, she said she feared for her and her son's lives if she tried.

At some point, Clarence became obsessed with another dancer at the club – 18-year-old Cheryl Ann Commesso. Cheryl had dreams of modelling for *Playboy*, and Clarence would take videos of her topless, saying he was going to send it to the publication and make her famous. But he would also try to make her sleep with him. When she refused, he'd turn violent.

One night, Cheryl left town after an argument with Clarence in the club car park. Shortly after that, Tonya and Clarence also disappeared. Not much is known about what happened to the family next, but by April 1990, Tonya had decided to run away with a secret lover. She would never make it. Instead, she was found dying on the side of the

road in Oklahoma, seemingly hit by a car from behind while out on a grocery run, and leaving behind a mystery about who she really was.

FLOYD

Following Tonya's death, Clarence put Michael into foster care. The foster parents were concerned about the child, as he seemed to have developmental and behavioural issues, but he thrived with them, and in 1994, they set about adopting him. They needed to get Clarence's consent, but when his DNA was compared with Michael's to confirm paternity, there was no match. Clarence was not Michael's father.

However, that didn't stop Clarence deciding he wanted his "son" back. On 12 September 1994, Clarence went to Michael's school armed with a gun. He forced the principal, James Davis, to take him to Michael, then frogmarched them both out of the school and into his truck. Davis was later found handcuffed to a tree in woodland. With the abduction of the little boy, a full-scale

WORDS: LISA HOWELLS. PHOTOS: NETFLIX

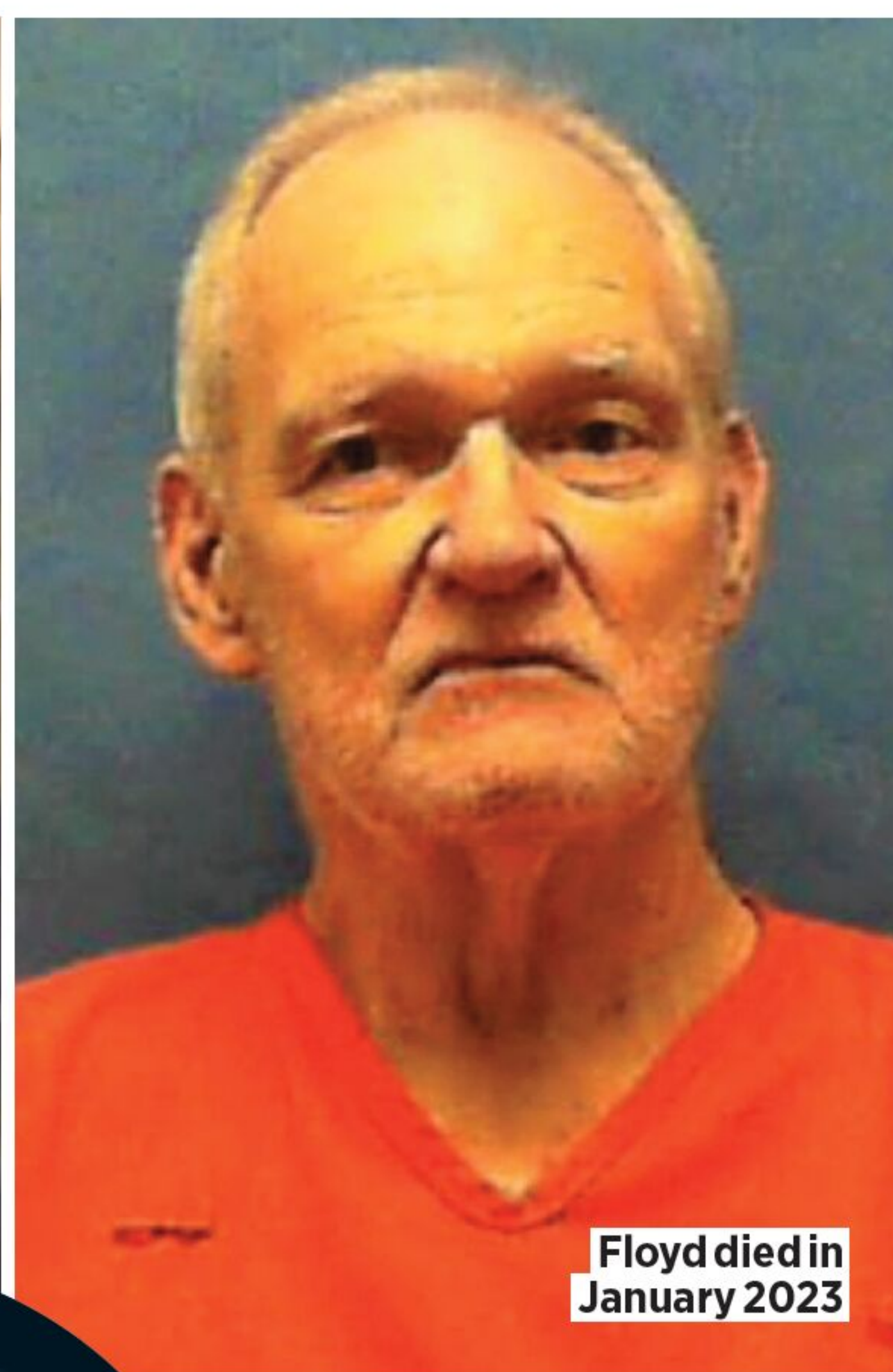
Michael
was shot



Cheryl Ann
Comnesso



Floyd died in
January 2023



'WHEN SHE GOT OUT OF JAIL, HER CHILDREN WERE GONE'

Following Michael's abduction, police put out alerts for all Floyd's known aliases, and they got lucky when he applied for a driver's licence in Kentucky. An officer posed as a mailman to deliver it, arresting Floyd as they handed it over. However, no one in his apartment building had ever seen Michael, and Floyd refused to say where the boy was, even when he was convicted of kidnap and sentenced to 52 years with no possibility of parole.

The whole story seemed almost too incredible to be true – and it was hard to believe that Floyd, when living as Warren Marshall, had married his own daughter. But they then realised that Floyd would have been in prison when Sharon was born, so he couldn't possibly be her father. A horrifying truth dawned. This was a man who'd gone on the run after abducting a child who wasn't his. Had he done it before?

SUZANNE

In 2002, the story came to the attention of journalist Matt Birkbeck. He started writing a book about Sharon, and his principal aim was to find out her true identity. Knowing there was only one man who could tell him, he went to interview Floyd in prison. But Floyd wouldn't reveal his secrets, so Matt had to publish the book without answering the central mystery that had begun to obsess him.

In 2011, the case was taken up by the National Center For Missing & Exploited Children, and two FBI officers once again went to visit Floyd. This time, though, they began to get answers. During one heated interview, they managed to get him to blurt out

a confession as to what had happened to Michael. Devastatingly, he admitted, "I shot him twice in the back of the head."

And now that Floyd had got that off his chest, his other secrets came spilling out. He told a story of how he had met

mother-of-four Sandra Brandenburg at a North Carolina truck stop in 1974. The pair began dating and moved in together with her children, but Sandra was arrested for passing bad cheques and given a month in jail. When she got out, Floyd and her kids were gone. The others had been dropped at an orphanage, but her six-year-old daughter, Suzanne Sevakis, had disappeared with Floyd.

Suzanne was held by Floyd from that day on, first raised as his daughter, Sharon Marshall, then made to become his wife, Tonya Hughes. It seems a miracle that she grew up to be a smart, popular, successful student, who had so much ahead of her before, presumably, a jealous Floyd killed her because she was daring to leave him.

And there was yet one more twist in the tale. In 1995, a mechanic found a set of photos taped underneath a truck that had once been stolen by Floyd. The photos showed not only Sharon in states of undress, but also a young woman who was being beaten and abused. The FBI sent the images out to various states, and a match was made with skeletal remains that had been discovered a short time before, near the I-275 in Florida. The body was that of Cheryl Ann Comnesso.

Floyd was convicted of first-degree murder and sentenced to death. He died in January 2023 of natural causes. ■

investigation was launched – and the FBI were to uncover a bombshell. Looking into Clarence, they found he'd tried to claim a life insurance policy on Tonya, but the social security number he'd provided had been under a different name. They realised then that the man calling himself Clarence Hughes was actually Franklin Delano Floyd – and Floyd had a serious criminal record.

In 1962, aged 19, he had abducted and raped a four-year-old girl, and a year later, he robbed a bank. He was sent to prison for a decade, but when he got out, he committed another assault. Charged but released on bail, Floyd absconded and went on the run for 17 years.

Once they realised they were dealing with a dangerous criminal, the police started wondering if he might have been responsible for his wife's death. News outlets ran with the story, putting Tonya's picture on screens nationwide. And that was when another shock came. Jenny Fisher called them to say Tonya was the girl she had known as Sharon Marshall – and that Clarence Hughes was her father Warren.